

Delhi Public Library vs Toronto Public Library

IFLA-aligned comparator report using an NCT service-area baseline

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Core finding. On IFLA's standard public-library metric frame, Delhi Public Library is not merely smaller than Toronto Public Library. It is operating at a different order of public reach. Using the NCT service-area denominator of 19.0 million residents, DPL records about **14,461 annual book issues per million residents**. TPL records about **9.33 million borrowings per million residents**. That is a **645x per-capita use gap**.

Denominator

The primary denominator is **NCT of Delhi**, not the full National Capital Region. DPL is treated as a Delhi service-area institution; comparing it to the full NCR would charge it for a wider regional population it does not formally cover. NCR is still useful as a latent-demand sensitivity, because readers and workers cross the NCT boundary, but it is not the headline denominator.

The old 2011-only denominator is not used for the main comparison. SevenT4 now uses the [theright2read](#) population correction source: `STATE_POP_MN["Delhi"] = 19`, which cites the MoHFW Technical Group population projections for 2011-2036. The exact annual Delhi row should still be promoted when the source PDF is reachable; the MoHFW server timed out during this session.

Area	Population used	Role
NCT of Delhi	19,000,000	Primary DPL service-area denominator
City of Toronto	3,000,000	Primary TPL service-area denominator
NCR sensitivity	27,000,000-32,000,000	Latent-demand sensitivity only

IFLA Frame

This report uses the IFLA Library Map of the World metric frame: service points, registered users, physical visits, physical loans, eBook loans, audio-book loans, downloads, staff, volunteers, and libraries with internet

access. The comparison below uses only fields that are currently captured from source reports. Missing IFLA fields are listed as data gaps rather than inferred.

IFLA-aligned metric	DPL, NCT baseline	TPL, city baseline	Reading
Conservative service points per 1M	2.1	34.0	TPL has 16.2x the service-point density.
Inclusive DPL touch-points per 1M	8.6	34.0	Even counting DPL mobile stops and reading centres, TPL is 4.0x denser.
Registered users per 1M	5,818	Not published in current TPL source	DPL has about one registered member per 172 NCT residents.
New card registrations per 1M	Not comparable	78,423	TPL reports new registrations, not total registered users.
Physical loans / borrowings per 1M	14,461	9,333,333	TPL is 645x higher per resident.
Physical visits proxy per 1M	17,646	4,466,667	DPL reports reading-room attendance, not all visits; TPL is 253x higher.
Collection items per 1M	80,396	3,500,000	TPL has 43.5x the collection density.
Annual additions per 1M	164	Not captured	DPL collection refresh is only 0.20%.

The most important warning is not simply that DPL has fewer outlets. It is that use is extremely low relative to both population and collection stock. DPL records **0.18 annual issues per collection item**. TPL records about **2.67 borrowings per collection item**. That is a 14.8x stock-turnover gap.

Finance

PPP conversion uses the World Bank [PA.NUS.PPP](#) indicator: India 2024 at 20.4219876045922 INR per international dollar, and Canada 2025 at 1.147294 CAD per international dollar.

Finance metric	DPL	TPL
Operating expenditure, PPP	\$16.11m intl.	\$258.05m intl.
Operating spend per resident, PPP	\$0.85	\$86.02
Spend per loan / borrowing, PPP	\$58.63	\$9.22
Materials expenditure, PPP	\$0.086m intl.	\$20.12m intl.
Materials spend per resident, PPP	\$0.0045	\$6.71
Materials share of expenditure	0.53%	7.80%

The finance interpretation is straightforward:

- TPL operates at 16.0x DPL's PPP expenditure scale.

- TPL spends 101.5x more per resident.
- DPL's low captured use makes spend per loan high despite low total funding.
- TPL's materials spending is over 230x DPL's PPP materials line and 1,481x higher per resident.
- DPL is not renewing or circulating stock at TPL-like intensity.

DPL's 2023-24 inflow is almost entirely grant-funded: grant receipts are 97.99% of grant plus other income, while other income is 2.01%. That is not a problem by itself; public libraries are public goods. The problem is that the public subsidy is not translating into visible public use.

DPL also ended 2023-24 with **INR 4.78 crore** in closing unspent balance. That is **14.5% of annual expenditure** and **27.2x the annual books and reading materials expense**. In a network with 49.6% staff vacancy and a 0.20% collection refresh rate, the unspent balance is operationally important.

DPL Timeline

The DPL extraction now emits the full online annual-report panel from 2009-10 through 2023-24. The online DPL source package contains annual reports for every year in that span; 2012-13, 2016-17, and 2020-21 required OCR recovery because the original [pdftotext](#) output was image-only or mostly blank.

Year	Members	Issues	Issues per 1M	Attendance	Collection	Additions	Refresh
2009-10	64,883	1,039,977	54,736	316,657	1,552,000	77,872	5.02%
2010-11	73,467	1,169,734	61,565	244,499	1,608,813	33,868	2.10%
2011-12	76,548	1,133,154	59,640	477,107	1,640,909	39,860	2.43%
2012-13	80,448	1,138,767	59,935	398,029	1,681,426	40,517	2.41%
2013-14	107,276	1,081,767	56,935	397,718	1,694,695	23,565	1.39%
2014-15	126,091	845,044	44,476	384,049	1,668,258	59,570	3.57%
2015-16	139,835	757,439	39,865	314,089	1,717,727	37,014	2.16%
2016-17	159,200	700,412	36,864	293,883	1,706,326	38,256	2.24%
2017-18	175,422	730,706	38,458	330,888	1,735,868	21,545	1.24%
2018-19	187,138	814,858	42,887	365,854	1,694,950	27,958	1.65%
2019-20	189,235	477,008	25,106	353,246	1,596,125	13,310	0.83%
2020-21	165,854	112,946	5,945	25,855	1,602,290	2,504	0.16%
2021-22	156,867	196,889	10,363	132,411	1,605,443	2,697	0.17%
2022-23	148,094	258,180	13,588	328,728	1,536,905	9,947	0.65%
2023-24	110,534	274,751	14,461	335,270	1,527,531	3,108	0.20%

The full online-run trend is severe. From 2009-10 to 2023-24, annual issues fall from 1,039,977 to 274,751, a 73.6% decline. Books added fall from 77,872 to 3,108, a 96.0% decline. Collection stock is roughly flat, moving from 1.55m to 1.53m items, so the collapse is not explained by a shrinking collection.

The peak-to-latest trend is sharper on active reach. Membership peaks at 189,235 in 2019-20 and falls to 110,534 in 2023-24, a 41.6% decline. Issues peak at 1.17m in 2010-11 and fall to 274,751 in 2023-24, a 76.5% decline.

Reading-room attendance is the one partial recovery signal: 2023-24 attendance is back near the 2017-18 to 2019-20 range. But reading-room recovery does not offset the collapse in issue activity and stock renewal.

Annual Toronto Comparison

For the annual comparison, DPL fiscal years are aligned to the TPL calendar year matching the DPL fiscal end year. TPL open data covers 2012-2023; DPL 2023-24 is compared to TPL's 2024 headline public metrics.

DPL year	TPL year	DPL issues per 1M	TPL borrowings per 1M	TPL/DPL ratio	DPL attendance per 1M	TPL branch visits per 1M	TPL/DPL visit ratio
2009-10	2010	54,736	Not available	Not available	16,666	Not available	Not available
2010-11	2011	61,565	Not available	Not available	12,868	Not available	Not available
2011-12	2012	59,640	10,677,345	179.0x	25,111	6,290,871	250.5x
2012-13	2013	59,935	10,715,007	178.8x	20,949	6,161,798	294.1x
2013-14	2014	56,935	10,678,265	187.6x	20,933	6,111,977	292.0x
2014-15	2015	44,476	10,835,321	243.6x	20,213	6,051,026	299.4x
2015-16	2016	39,865	10,636,859	266.8x	16,531	6,077,456	367.6x
2016-17	2017	36,864	10,032,963	272.2x	15,468	5,790,011	374.3x
2017-18	2018	38,458	10,185,190	264.8x	17,415	5,859,124	336.4x
2018-19	2019	42,887	10,220,678	238.3x	19,256	5,749,587	298.6x
2019-20	2020	25,106	7,000,305	278.8x	18,592	1,852,584	99.6x
2020-21	2021	5,945	8,076,365	1,358.6x	1,361	1,343,163	987.0x
2021-22	2022	10,363	8,866,311	855.6x	6,969	3,188,829	457.6x
2022-23	2023	13,588	8,330,966	613.1x	17,302	4,169,274	241.0x
2023-24	2024	14,461	9,333,333	645.4x	17,646	4,466,667	253.1x

This comparison shows that the gap is not a one-year artefact. Before COVID, TPL already records roughly 179x-278x DPL's per-capita borrowing. After the DPL collapse in 2020-21, the ratio remains above 600x in the latest two comparable years.

NCR Sensitivity

If the full NCR population range of 27-32 million is used as a shadow catchment, the DPL position worsens. This is not the primary comparison, but it matters for latent reading demand.

Catchment sensitivity	Population	Service points per 1M	Issues per 1M	Reading-room attendance per 1M	PPP spend per resident
NCR low	27,000,000	1.48	10,176	12,417	\$0.60
NCR high	32,000,000	1.25	8,586	10,477	\$0.50

The NCT denominator is therefore the conservative baseline. It does not make DPL look worse; it makes the comparison administratively fair.

Data Gaps

DPL reporting now covers many core operational fields, but several IFLA metrics are still missing or incomplete:

- all physical visits, not only reading-room attendance;
- eBook loans;
- audio-book loans;
- downloads;
- libraries with internet access;

- full-time staff in IFLA-compatible form;
- volunteers;
- digital sessions, public computers, Wi-Fi sessions, and programme attendance.

TPL's current public pages expose richer digital, programme, and branch-visit data, but do not expose total registered users in the same way DPL reports membership. The report therefore compares TPL new card registrations separately and does not pretend they are equivalent to DPL registered-member stock.

Working Conclusions

1. DPL should be compared on NCT, not NCR, for the main service-area baseline.
2. Even on the conservative NCT denominator, DPL's service density, borrowing, collection density, materials spending, and collection renewal are far below Toronto's.
3. DPL's current problem is both under-resourcing and low conversion of existing stock into public use.
4. Grant dependence is normal for a public library. The red flag is that 98% grant-funded operations produce extremely low per-capita use and very low materials renewal.
5. The next Delhi extraction should prioritize full DPL annual reports, branch locations, service hours, digital services, programmes, and staff deployment by branch so the IFLA frame can be completed.

Source Base

- Delhi Public Library annual reports page: <https://dpl.gov.in/index.php/annual-reports>
- Delhi Public Library Annual Report 2023-24: https://drive.google.com/file/d/1d6K6glvU5osL5ck9tR_2LLuoHFQUeh0e/view?usp=sharing
- Toronto Public Library, About the Library: <https://tpl.ca/about-the-library/>
- Toronto Public Library, Library Finance: <https://tpl.ca/about-the-library/library-finance/>
- Toronto Public Library, Open Data: <https://tpl.ca/about-the-library/open-data/>
- IFLA Library Map of the World, Data Lab: <https://librarymap.ifla.org/datalab>
- IFLA Library Map of the World, About Library Data: <https://librarymap.ifla.org/about-library-data>
- IFLA-UNESCO Public Library Manifesto 2022: <https://www.ifla.org/publications/ifla-unesco-public-library-manifesto-2022/>
- World Bank PPP conversion factor, GDP, PA.NUS.PPP: https://api.worldbank.org/v2/country/IND;CAN/indicator/PA.NUS.PPP?format=json&per_page=100
- Local SevenT4
 derived tables: `data/cities/delhi/source/libraries/dpl_online_annual_time_series.csv`, `data/cities/delhi/source/libraries/dpl_ten_year_time_series.csv`, `data/comparators/delhi_toronto/annual_usage_comparison.csv`, `data/comparators/delhi_toronto/library_comparison_metrics.csv`, `data/comparators/delhi_toronto/library_comparison_summary.json`